

Culture Unit (I)

親屬稱謂 — Kinship Titles

Let's Learn Mandarin · Book 1

Why is Wang Mingmei Wang Mingwen's "táng" younger sister, while Zhang An'an is his "biǎo" younger sister?

In ancient China, the family unit was large, and most relatives with family ties would live together. Because Chinese people place great importance on kinship relationships between people, and on the hierarchy of generations and seniority, even though everyone in the group is family, each person plays a different role within the family. Every person has a fixed term of address for every other person (relative), and when different terms are used, outsiders can immediately tell what relationship exists between them.

Terms for relatives on the **father's side** include:

- 爺爺 (yéye) — "father's father" (paternal grandfather)
- 奶奶 (nǎinai) — "father's mother" (paternal grandmother)
- 伯伯 (bóbo) — "father's older brother" (paternal uncle, elder)
- 叔叔 (shūshu) — "father's younger brother" (paternal uncle, younger)
- 姑姑 (gūgu) — "father's sister" (paternal aunt)

Terms for relatives on the **mother's side** include:

- 外公 (wàigōng) — "mother's father" (maternal grandfather)
- 外婆 (wàipó) — "mother's mother" (maternal grandmother)
- 舅舅 (jiùjiu) — "mother's brother" (maternal uncle)
- 阿姨 (āyí) — "mother's sister" (maternal aunt)

The sons and daughters of my 伯伯 and 叔叔 (paternal uncles, father's brothers) are my "堂" (**táng**) cousins — cousins on the father's side through his brothers.

The sons and daughters of my 姑姑 (paternal aunt), 舅舅 (maternal uncle), and 阿姨 (maternal aunt) are my "表" (**biǎo**) cousins — cousins through any other branch of the family.

Cultural Note: Chinese distinguishes paternal-line cousins (堂, from father's brothers) from cross-line cousins (表, from any aunt or maternal uncle) — a distinction that English simply collapses into the single word "cousin."